

LINUX DISTRIBUTIONS

In the past three years more and more people have been trying out Linux on the desktop, driven primarily by the large number of free productivity and entertainment applications that have been appearing for Linux, which are as easy to use as their Windows counterparts. Distributions such as SuSe, Mandrake and Caldera's e-Desktop are designed to appeal to desktop users as an alternative to Windows. While Linux is still far from being accepted as a substitute for Windows for the majority of people, these new versions of Linux are much easier to install and configure than in the past. Desktop environments such as KDE and Gnome provide users with a familiar Windows-like GUI, while the basic operating system continues to evolve and offer much better hardware compatibility, amongst other things.

Installing Linux on your PC has become so simple that in some cases it is actually easier than installing Windows 98. As support for new hardware continues to grow and an increasing number of serious applications and games appear, Linux will continue to

become a friendlier option for Desktop PC

users. The arrival of Windows XP, which provides an even friendlier interface built upon a more stable core, will provide a huge challenge.



SuSE Linux 7.2 Professional

With a plethora of bundled applications, SuSE makes installation and usage very easy

This distribution builds on the stability of the basic OS itself and adds a whole lot of programs such as Office productivity applications, media editing and viewing tools, plenty of games, and the impressive Star Office suite. In addition, SuSE really stands out because of its excellent set of manuals that make it very simple to use.

+ Large number of usable packages

+ Easy installation

Price: Rs 2,000

Contact: GT Enterprises

Phone: 080-6606093

Fax: 080-6671407

E-mail: gtcldrom@vsnl.com

Web site: www.suse.com

Reviewed in: August 2001

Worthy Mentions

Red Hat Linux 7.1

+ Good hardware detection and application set

Price: Rs 5,650

Contact: GT Enterprises

Phone: 080-6606093

Fax: 080-6671407

E-mail: gtcldrom@vsnl.com

Web site: www.redhat.com

Reviewed in: August 2001

Mandrake Linux 8.0

+ Good set of window managers to choose from

Price: Rs 1,750

Contact: GT Enterprises

Phone: 080-6606093

Fax: 080-6671407

Reviewed in: August 2001

E-mail: gtcldrom@vsnl.com

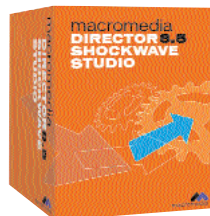
Web site: www.linux-mandrake.com

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: SuSe Linux 6.4 1999: Red Hat Linux 6.0 1998: NA

MULTIMEDIA AUTHORIZING TOOLS

With the increasing popularity of CDs as a medium of distribution for interactive presentations, and with the growing popularity of animated content on Web sites and other media, multimedia authoring applications have grown to accommodate a greater number of formats and very tight integration with the Internet. New versions of software incorporate intuitive interfaces and increased WYSIWYG capabilities. This ensures that users can concentrate on exercising creativity instead of having to master a steep learning curve. Developments in multimedia authoring tools seem to have followed a pattern similar to what we saw in the case of image editing software. Macromedia Director dominates the category. With the integration of Shockwave, Director has become much more Web friendly and also continues to include support for newer formats such as 3D elements.

Watch for 3D animations, which will play an important role in the future with support for more formats and better integration of 3D elements.



Macromedia's Director 8.5 Shockwave Studio

A versatile multimedia content production tool that lets you create CD-ROMs, kiosk-based presentations, and Shockwave movies for the Internet

Macromedia's Director can import almost any type of element, whether it is text, animation, images or video. It has almost become the *de facto* standard when it comes to multimedia application development and also has robust scripting capabilities. The latest version opens itself up by extending support to 3D objects.

+ Powerful scripting capability and better compression tools for the Web

+ Support for 3D objects and behaviours

Price: Rs 47,950

Contact: Wipro Infotech

Phone: 080-8440011

Fax: 080-8440187

E-mail: surajs@wipro.co.in

Web site: www.wipro.com

Reviewed in: September 2001

Worthy Mentions

Macromedia Flash 5

+ Allows layer-based animation

+ Support for XML extends functionality

Price: Rs 19,150

Contact: Wipro Infotech

Phone: 080-8440011

Fax: 080-8440187

E-mail: surajs@wipro.co.in

URL: www.wipro.com

Reviewed in: September 2001

Adobe Live Motion 1.02

+ Provides a good set of filters

+ Custom animation is possible

Price: Rs 17,765

Contact: Adobe Systems (I) Pvt Ltd

Phone: 0118-4532026

Fax: 0118-4532010

E-mail: sandeepm@adobe.com

Web site: www.adobe.com

Reviewed in: September 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: NA 1999: NA 1998: Macromedia Director 6.0